PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #36 · DEPRESSION

“I’m no good. I never have been.”

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Where it often comes from

Some people hear “you are no good” so early that they cannot remember a time before it. Criticism, comparison, abuse, shame, or a home where love had to be earned can plant the sentence in childhood. Later mistakes seem only to confirm an old verdict. Depression treats the verdict as history: not “I did wrong,” but “I have never been any good.” That is a story about the whole past, and it leaves out how God made you and how He loves you.

What Scripture teaches

The Bible is honest about sin, and it is also clear about creation and redemption. “I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made.” We are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus. He is among His people, and He quiets them with His love. Christ died for us while we were still sinners, which means His love did not wait until we were “good enough.” Being no good in your own eyes is not the same thing as being worthless to God.

> *“I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well”* (Psalm 139:14).

Also see

> “For we are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life” (Ephesians 2:10).

> “The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing” (Zephaniah 3:17).

> “But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us” (Romans 5:8).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

Common self-statements

- There has never been anything good in me.
- I was a mistake from the start.
- Other people were born worthwhile. I was not.
- Any good I do is fake.
- God regrets making me.
- I should not take up anyone’s time.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling my whole life “no good” because of shame or sin.
- Overgeneralization: Erasing every good thing across every year.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling worthless and treating the feeling as my history.
- Discounting the positive: Refusing to count love, effort, or gifts that do not fit the verdict.

Challenging questions

- Who first told me I was no good, and were they right about all of me?
- What good has been present in me that this sentence leaves out?

- Is “never” something I can actually know about my whole life?
- Would I say “you have never been any good” to a child I love?
- What does God say about how I was made and how Christ loves me?
- What is one good thing I can acknowledge without calling it fake?

Truth summary

> I am not worthless. God made me and calls me His workmanship, even with my failures and wounds.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

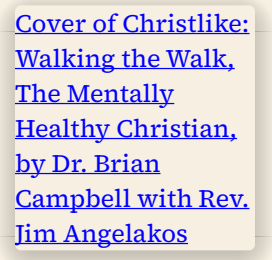
- Self-Esteem, Low
- God, Creator
- Love, By God
- Thinking, Healthy
- Guilt/Shame

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love
- Depression

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from “The Mentally Healthy Christian” (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

You Say — Lauren Daigle

God's loving word challenges a name built only on weakness.

Good Good Father — Chris Tomlin

The Father's love is deeper than the verdict you grew up with.

Clean — Natalie Grant

Shame does not put you beyond God's restoring grace.

How Great Thou Art — Jordan Smith

The God who made you is great, and you are among His works.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm no good. I never have been."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm no good. I never have been." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who first told me I was no good, and were they right about all of me?
- ☐ What good has been present in me that this sentence leaves out?
- ☐ Is "never" something I can actually know about my whole life?
- ☐ Would I say "you have never been any good" to a child I love?
- ☐ What does God say about how I was made and how Christ loves me?
- ☐ What is one good thing I can acknowledge without calling it fake?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am not worthless. God made me and calls me His workmanship, even with my failures and wounds.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ A hard history does not make me no good.
- ☐ God's love reached me before I was impressive.
- ☐ I can admit sin without erasing my whole life.
- ☐ I am God's workmanship, not a regret.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 139:14
  "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ Ephesians 2:10
  "For we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life."
- ☐ Zephaniah 3:17
  "The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When the "no good" feeling came: Each day, write down one moment when the old verdict felt true. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 139:14 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am fearfully and wonderfully made. I am not no good.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio or the Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Write a truer history. List five moments of goodness, courage, or love in your life, however small. The lie says there are none.
- [ ] Retire the old sentence. When you hear "I'm no good," answer aloud with Psalm 139:14.
- [ ] Tell a safe person the verdict. Say the sentence you grew up with, and ask what they see instead. Write their answer.
- [ ] Do one good thing on purpose this week, a kindness or a faithful task, and let it count.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm no good. I never have been.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment I was not "no good"
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm no good. I never have been~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have called myself no good for a long time. Teach me the truth about how You made me and how You love me, and heal the old verdict. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.